AN ILLUSTRATED ADVENTURE FOR THE TI-99/4A



THE OBSIDIAN CLOCK

Sierra del Humo, 1934

PLAYER'S GUIDE

Version 1.0 · Requires the 32K memory expansion · F18A enhanced

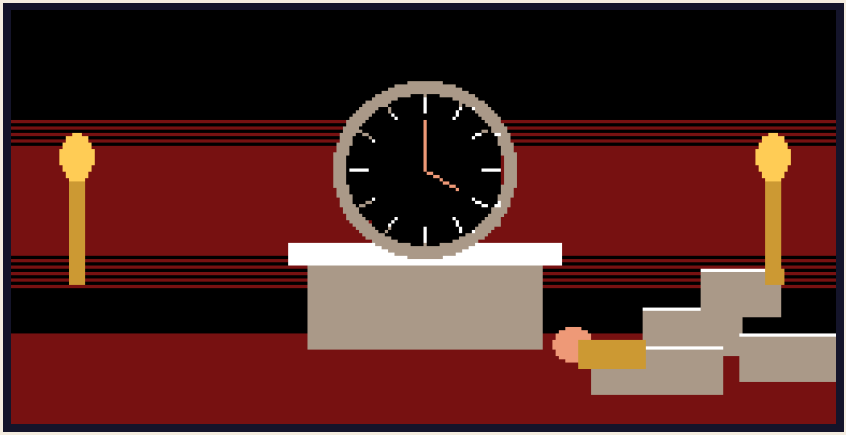
The Story

The rains are a day away. When they break, the river will rise and the valley will drown, and whatever lies in its ruins will be lost for another thousand years.

You are **Dr. Ada Vance**, archaeologist. Your pilot, Teo, has just set his patched biplane down on a grass strip hacked from the cloud forests of the Sierra del Humo. Somewhere beneath the great pyramid beyond lies the **Obsidian Clock**: a disc of black volcanic glass carved with the days of a lost year, the calendar stone of a forgotten people.

You are not the first to come looking. **Silas Grieve**, a dealer in stolen relics, made camp in the ruins days ago, and nobody has seen him since.

Find the clock. Then get back to the plane before the water does.



The clock chamber, as it appears with the F18A's tuned colors.

Getting Started

What you need

A TI-99/4A with the **32K memory expansion**, and the cartridge file **obsidian8.bin** on a FinalGROM 99 or in an emulator such as js99er or Classic99. No disk drive, speech or SAMS is needed. An F18A is optional: if you have one, the game uses it automatically.

Starting the game

Choose **THE OBSIDIAN CLOCK** from the TI menu. The title picture appears and a short tune plays. When it ends, press **ENTER**. Read the introduction, pressing any key at `--MORE--`, and you will find yourself at the airstrip.

The game cannot save your progress, so set aside time to play in one sitting.

The screen

The top of the screen shows a picture of where you are. The eight lines below it are the story. When the game is ready for you, it shows a prompt and a cursor:

```
> _
```

Each command you give clears the text and starts fresh: your command at the top, the answer beneath it. If an answer runs long, the game pauses at `--MORE--`; press any key to read on.

Keys pressed while a picture is drawing or a tune is playing are not seen. If nothing happens, wait a moment and press again.

Giving Commands

Type a command of one or two words and press **ENTER**: a verb, and usually the thing you want to act on.

```
> TAKE LAMP
> OPEN CRATE
> EXAMINE TREE
```

Moving

Type a direction: `NORTH`, `SOUTH`, `EAST`, `WEST`, `UP` or `DOWN`, or just its first letter. `GO NORTH` works too. Each description tells you which ways lead somewhere.

Longer sentences

The game reads the first two words that matter and skips small ones such as THE, A, AT, TO, WITH and IN. So `LOOK AT THE STELA` means `EXAMINE STELA`, and `CUT VINES WITH MACHETE` means `CUT VINES`. You never need to say what you are using: if you are carrying the right thing, it works.

Only the first six letters of a word count, so LANTERN and LANTERNS are the same word.

Editing what you type

Key	What it does
FCTN-S ←	Erase the last letter (FCTN-1 also works)
FCTN-E ↑	Bring back your last command
FCTN-D →	Re-type your last command one letter at a time
FCTN-X ↓	Clear the line (FCTN-3 also works)

In an emulator, your PC's Backspace and arrow keys do the same. Capital letters only; ALPHA LOCK makes no difference.

Words the Game Knows

Words on the same row mean the same thing.

Verb	Also	What it does
LOOK	L	Describe where you are
EXAMINE	X, INSPECT, SEARCH	Look closely at something
READ		Read writing
INVENTORY	I, INV	List what you carry
TAKE	GET, GRAB	Pick something up
DROP	LEAVE	Put something down
OPEN		Open things
CUT	CHOP, HACK, SLASH	Cut, with a blade
LIGHT	IGNITE	Light things
TIE	KNOT	Tie things
PRY	LEVER, FORCE, MOVE, LIFT	Shift heavy things
PRESS	PUSH, TOUCH	Press things
TALK	ASK, SPEAK	Talk to someone
FREE	RESCUE	Free someone stuck
BOARD	ENTER, FLY	Climb aboard
WAIT	Z	Let a moment pass
SCORE		Show your score
HELP	HINT	How to give commands
QUIT		End the game

Directions: NORTH (N), SOUTH (S), EAST (E), WEST (W), UP (U, CLIMB), DOWN (D, DESCEND).

Time, Danger and Glory

Every command the game understands takes one turn. The weather keeps its own time: dawdle long enough and the rains will come on their own, and some deeds may bring them sooner. Once the rain starts, the game warns you as the water rises, and you have only a handful of turns to reach safety.

There are a few ways for the adventure to end badly. When it ends, win or lose, you see your score and the question **PLAY AGAIN? (Y/N)**. Press **Y** to begin again, or **N** to return to the TI title screen.

The perfect score is **100 points**. Points come from solving problems and from a few acts of decency along the way, not only from reaching the end. Type `SCORE` at any time.

F18A enhanced color

If your console has an F18A, the game finds it when it starts, and every scene gets its own tuned colors: layered greens and bark-brown trunks in the jungle, murky water at the ford, warm limestone in the ruins, amber lantern light on the stairs. The story text stays white on black. When you quit, the standard colors are put back for the next program.



The jungle trail, with the F18A's palette.

Advice for Adventurers

None of these will spoil a puzzle.

Examine everything. Descriptions mention more than what you can carry. Containers, carvings and people often have more to say when you look closely or search them.

Read what is written. Your field journal is a good place to start.

Talk to people. Not everyone you meet is an enemy, and some know this country better than you.

Think about the way back. Reaching the clock is only half the adventure. What is easy to cross on the way in may not be on the way out.

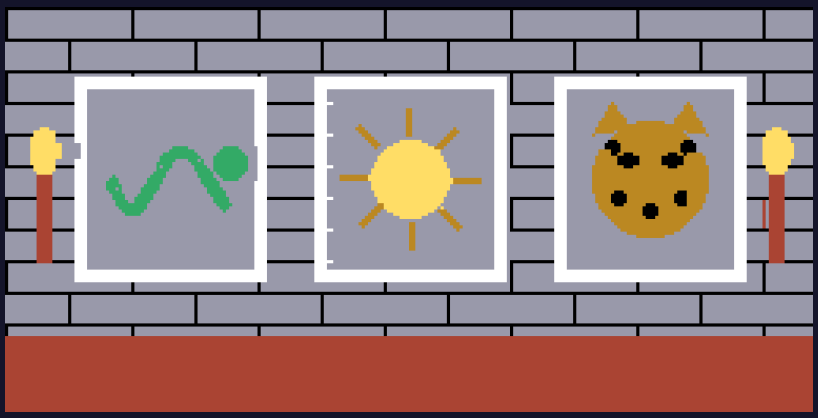
Be prepared before you go somewhere dark.

Make a map. Note each place and which way leads where. There are nine of them.

Kindness counts. Not every point comes from treasure.

If something goes wrong

Problem	Try
`Not on the menu`	Name the file obsidian8.bin and load it as a cartridge.
`A message asks for 32K`	Add the 32K memory expansion (in an emulator, turn it on) and restart.
`A key is ignored`	Wait for the picture or tune to finish, then press again.
`No F18A colors`	In js99er, enable the F18A in its settings and restart.



Find the clock.
Then get back to the plane
before the water does.

THE OBSIDIAN CLOCK

An original illustrated adventure for the TI-99/4A.
Story, text, art, engine and tools by Rebecca Sutter,
built with Claude, 2026.

TI-99/4A with 32K memory expansion · FinalGROM 99 or emulator
Enhanced for the F18A · Version 1.0